

The Diaspora *Ledger*

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Check it yourself.

The Money Comes Home. The House Rarely Does.

Africa's diaspora is now one of the continent's biggest real-estate investors, and among its most defrauded. Below is what we found, with every source linked so the team can read it first-hand and form its own view.

A DIASPORAHOME WORKING BRIEF · SOURCES: [R/NIGERIA](#), [LINKEDIN](#), AND A LIVE LOOK AT THE STARTUPS ALREADY DOING THIS

Every year the African diaspora wires billions of dollars back to the continent to buy land and raise houses they plan to retire into. A lot of that money never becomes a wall. It disappears into relatives who "handled it," contractors who vanished, duplicate listings, and inflated invoices. The people living it have largely stopped calling it a scandal and started treating it as normal.

This is not a survey we commissioned. It is a public argument already happening. On [r/Nigeria](#), a diaspora member posted almost the exact question our idea answers: could you keep control of a build from abroad, with a verified plan you own, staged payments, real proof of progress, and an accountable professional on site? Forty comments answered. They did not really debate whether the pain was real. They debated how to survive it. Worth reading in full before we decide anything.

THE PAIN HAS A SHAPE, AND IT IS FAMILY

The most upvoted post on the subject, ["Do Not Build House Back Home"](#), does not soften it: family members "scheming off the top, lying about prices, spending the money and not building anything at all" for

someone who spent a decade abroad. One user counted thirteen siblings and trusted exactly one. It is worth clicking through to see how many people agree in the comments.

Underneath the theft sits a second, quieter loss that few name out loud, until they do. The single highest voted comment on the main thread argues against building at all: put the money in an index fund instead, partly to hedge *foreign-exchange devaluation* eating the value of the property. That view narrows the easy market. It may also point at something useful: the currency worry is already on people's minds, and none of the companies below seem to address it.

WHY THIS LOOKS WORTH PURSUING

A build back home asks one person to wire their savings across an ocean and answer four separate questions of trust: will the money be diverted, is the reported progress real, is my money's *value* surviving the journey, and do I have to manage all of it alone from thousands of miles away? The market has answered the first two well. The last two look thinner, and that is where the interesting conversation for our team probably is.

BY THE NUMBERS

From the sources linked below

\$20bn+	remitted home by diaspora Nigerians in 2023, Africa's top remittance destination
1,577	real-estate fraud petitions to LASRERA, 2020 to early 2024
122	upvotes on one "do not build back home" warning, with 79 comments
1 of 13	siblings one diaspora builder said he could actually trust
8	companies we found already building a version of this

VOICES FROM THE FIELD

Unsolicited, on [r/Nigeria](#). Short and paraphrased; click to read in full.

“Uncles who handled it, siblings who squandered it, contractors who vanished.”

[R/NIGERIA, 40-COMMENT THREAD](#)

“Brothers and sisters will do it to their siblings. Mothers to their sons.

“DO NOT BUILD HOUSE BACK HOME”, 122 PTS

“People hand huge decisions to relatives who mean well but don't understand development, and because it's family nobody asks the hard questions.

DIASPORA INVESTOR, PR/CITIZENSHIP THREAD

MARKET WATCH

Who Is Already Building This

The core idea, verified contractors plus milestone escrow plus on-site inspection for diaspora builders, is **already out there, and one company uses almost our exact tagline**. Every name below links to its site, checked this week, so the team can poke around directly. There are surely things you will notice that we missed. Read the status column like a markets page.

COMPANY	WHAT IT IS	STATUS	WORTH NOTING
BuildWatch mybuildwatch.com	"GPS-verified, inspector-led, escrow-secured." Very close to our pitch. 6-stage tracking, 40-point checklist, inspectors rotated every 90 days. 200+ ON WAITLIST, NO LIVE APP YET	— WAITLIST	Fiat only, so no currency protection. Notifies rather than acts. Not yet shipped.
DiasporaBuild diasporabuild.com	"Upwork for construction": contractor marketplace, escrow wallet, staged release after inspection, daily photo tracker. LIVE IN CAMEROON AND NIGERIA	▲ LIVE	Fiat, human-managed. Already pan-African. No currency or AI layer.
Pencil Home pencilhomes.com	24/7 live CCTV, weekly photo/video, budget dashboard, 3D pre-viz, land verification, site supervision. FULL SERVICE, CONTACT STILL A PLACEHOLDER	▲ LIVE	"Diaspora-friendly payments" is vague, with no clear escrow and no FX.
Propy Mould propymould.com	Design-build with a dedicated PM, milestone payments, weekly receipts, photos, inspection reports and logs. PAN-AFRICAN, "ACROSS AFRICA"	▲ LIVE	Fiat. Agency model is labour-heavy to scale. No AI or currency angle.
SimpleXD simplexd.co	Purchase verification, build monitoring, drone footage, weekly reports, budget tracking. Recently added a local, in-country focus too. LIVE, EXPANDING AUDIENCE	▲ LIVE	Monitoring focused. No custody, currency, or automation.
NaijaSight naijasight.com	Boots-on-ground inspection and verification, construction monitoring per visit, title checks, drone media. Flat \$79 to \$149. LIVE PRICING, NATIONWIDE	▲ LIVE	Inspection only. No custody, currency, or automation.
HouseAfrica sytemap	Blockchain land registry and tokenised sitemaps. 20,000+ users, exclusive REDAN partnership, ₦1.5bn sales facilitated. GROWING, ROUGHLY 9 TO 10 MONTHS RUNWAY	▲ LIVE	Title side, not build custody. Strong traction, but raising now.
Seso Global sesoglobal.com	The best-funded, most-hyped "trust for African real estate" player. Raised \$620k, opened US and UK offices, then went quiet. SITE ERRORS OUT, NO NEW FUNDING SINCE 2021	▼ STALLED	A reminder that funding alone did not settle this market.

▲ LIVE

SHIPPING TO REAL USERS

— WAITLIST

ANNOUNCED, NOT LAUNCHED

▼ STALLED

FUNDED, THEN DORMANT

SUGGESTIONS

Two Ideas For the Team to Weigh

If you break the diaspora builder's need into four atoms of trust, two already look well served by the companies above, and two look thinner. **None of this is decided**. These are starting points for the team to challenge, not conclusions.

"WILL MY MONEY BE DIVERTED?" Custody Escrow that releases on milestones, as with BuildWatch and DiasporaBuild. LOOKS WELL SERVED	"IS THE PROGRESS REAL?" Verification GPS-tagged photos plus an inspector checklist. Common across the field. LOOKS WELL SERVED	"IS MY MONEY'S VALUE SURVIVING?" Currency integrity Everyone we found holds fiat. Devaluation quietly eats the dollars, and users raise this themselves. LOOKS THIN, WORTH EXPLORING	"MUST I RUN THIS ALONE?" Agency The best competitors send alerts. We did not find one that acts on the owner's behalf. LOOKS THIN, WORTH EXPLORING
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IDEA TO EXPLORE 01

Hold funds in a stable currency

One option worth discussing: fund milestones in a dollar-stable coin held in escrow, so devaluation is less able to eat the build. It speaks to the currency worry the diaspora raises unprompted, and a testnet version could sidestep most licensing questions for a demo. Open for the team to pressure-test, including whether it is the right call at all.

IDEA TO EXPLORE 02

An assistant that does the chasing

Another direction: an assistant that reads each inspection report against the milestone plan, flags anything that looks off, and only suggests releasing money once a milestone genuinely passes. Where competitors notify, this would help manage. Whether it is realistic to build well in our timeline is exactly the kind of thing to hash out together.

SEE IT YOURSELF

Every Source, Linked

Nothing here should be taken on our word. Open the threads, read the comments, click through the startups. If something changes your read, that is the point.

DIASPORA VOICES

Public Reddit threads, r/Nigeria

Would you trust someone back home with millions to build your house?

40 COMMENTS · WRITES OUR IDEA AS A QUESTION
old.reddit.com/r/Nigeria/comments/1uo7p6b

DO. NOT. BUILD. HOUSE. BACK. HOME.

122 PTS · 79 COMMENTS
old.reddit.com/r/Nigeria/comments/1ngtq6x

PR/citizenship abroad, did you still buy back home?

24 COMMENTS
old.reddit.com/r/Nigeria/comments/1t9guw0

MARKET SCALE

The numbers in the factbox

Zedo Proptech, diaspora fraud stats (LinkedIn)

\$20BN REMITTANCES · 1,577 LASRERA PETITIONS
linkedin.com/posts/zedo-proptech...

The diaspora as Africa's largest real-estate investor

CONTEXT ON THE PAN-AFRICAN MARKET
brif.africa/article/the-diaspora...

Sytemap / HouseAfrica traction (TechCabal, 2026)

USERS, REDAN DEAL, RUNWAY
techcabal.com/2026/02/27/sytemap...

THE STARTUPS DOING IT

Go look, form your own view

BuildWatch

mybuildwatch.com

DiasporaBuild

diasporabuild.com

Pencil Home

pencilhomes.com

Propy Mould

propymould.com

SimpleXD

simplexd.co

NaijaSight

naijasight.com

Seso Global

sesoglobal.com (currently down)

OPEN QUESTIONS FOR THE TEAM

Nothing above is a decision. Here is what feels worth settling together before we commit.

Q1 Is the pain in these threads strong and common enough to build a whole project on, once you have read them yourselves?

Q2 Of the two thin atoms, currency and agency, does either feel like a real edge, or is it just harder to build and easy to overrate?

Q3 Looking at the live startups, what are they doing better than we assumed, and where could a small team realistically stand out in the fellowship window?

ABOUT THIS BRIEF. Compiled for the Africa Intellect Fellowship 2.0, July 2026. Quotes are short and paraphrased; open the linked threads for full context. Competitor status was checked live this week and can shift. Figures on remittances and fraud come from the Zedo Proptech post, citing the World Bank Migration and Development Brief 39, Premium Times, and Nairametrics. Framed for the African diaspora rather than Nigeria alone, since the pain and the competition are already continental.